

The Audiobook Project Based Learning: An Approach Aimed at Improving Students' English Reading Fluency

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Abstract—Since one of the objectives of the English in Focus (EIF) class was to help students improve their reading fluency, the research aimed to investigate the effects of an audiobook project on students' reading fluency in the EIF class based on students' perception. The participants were students from two EIF classes, for a total of eighty-three students. The investigation was conducted using a qualitative approach, and the data were gathered using a questionnaire. The questionnaire was divided into two parts: the first consisted of fifteen statements accompanied by a Likert scale, and the second contained two open-ended questions designed to collect more detailed information. Within 7 meetings, the audiobook implementation project was successfully finished. After finishing the audiobook project, the students' reading fluency and experience were significantly enhanced, as demonstrated by the results of the research. During the course of working on the audiobook project, students were able to demonstrate correct intonation and articulation when reading English text, learned new words, and improved their ability to work together on the project by discussing it with the other members of their group. In conclusion, based on students' perception, the research findings indicate that implementing an audiobook project to improve reading fluency is viable.

Keywords—project-based learning, audiobook, reading fluency, literature material

I. INTRODUCTION

English as a foreign language education aims to help students understand and use the target language effectively, including improving their listening, reading, speaking, and writing skills from basic to advanced level ability. One of the English skills that need to be improved is reading skills. In the class with many challenges, improving reading skills becomes one of the crucial objectives of the class. The lecturer cannot check all the students reading text understanding at once in the class and at every meeting. Then, reading has some purposes, including reading in language learning, reading for language learning, reading for information, and reading for pleasure [1]. The lecturer may create an appropriate atmosphere to ensure that the reading activity's purposes can be achieved.

Then, as in [2], reading comprehension and fluency are crucial language skills for many aspects of life. Reading comprehension is a skill that allows students to develop their skills in various subjects continually, including reading fluency. Consequently, assessing students' reading comprehension and fluency is essential for systematically gathering information and drawing conclusions about a

student's ability or the quality of the learning process [3]. Specifically, reading fluency is essential because it connects knowing words and understanding what it means. The students can find connections between what they are reading, what they already know, and they can focus on understanding what is being said.

Additionally, it is also applicable in the English in Focus class, a program designed for Upper Beginner students with a BUEPT at one university in Bandung, with a proficiency test score ranging from 433 to 463. One of the course objectives is to improve students' reading skills and fluency. As the preliminary research result found that most students' reading fluency and comprehension are at a beginning level. Some of them had difficulty reading a short text with fluency and understanding. Because of that reason, an appropriate teaching and learning activity is needed, and one of them is by using audiobook.

Moreover, reading fluency refers to the students' capacity to read text with appropriate speed, accuracy, and expression [2]. Proficient reading skills are essential for the students to comprehend written material effectively. The phenomenon is applicable to both the act of reading silently and the act of reading aloud. Reading fluency is essential because it fosters comprehension and inspires readers. It has been called a link between reading phases such as early reading and advanced reading.

Fluent reading requires a combination of good accuracy, expression, and comprehension [2],[3]. First, reading words accurately is essential to developing fluency as the students must be able to read words without pausing to sound them out or break them into chunks. When the students can accurately and easily read the words in a text, they are able to think about what they are reading rather than putting all of their effort toward figuring out the words. Second, speed refers to the ability of students to read fluently and efficiently at a consistent rate. Third, expression in fluency refers to the capacity to read in a manner that mimics the sound of spoken language. It indicates that the students reads aloud with appropriate expression, pauses for periods and commas, and emphasizes key words. Additionally, expression indicates that the students comprehend what is being read. When engaging in the activity, individuals who possess a high level of reading proficiency are capable of comprehending textual phrases and appropriately incorporating intonation as required.

Consequently, their reading proficiency is enhanced, resulting in a more fluent and eloquent delivery.

Audiobooks are recorded versions of printed books' narrations that users can listen to and repeat while reading the book's printed version [4],[5],[6]. Moreover, audiobook technology can be utilized cleverly to achieve the desired outcome in a reading class. According to [7], audiobooks appeared successful as a teaching-learning strategy because they led to significant cognitive enhancements.

Then, an appropriate strategy is required to apply the audiobook in the classroom, and one of them is a project-based learning. Project-Based Learning is an instructional approach that effectively involves students in the process of learning by necessitating them to accomplish a project that is centred around real-world problems encountered during the learning journey [8]. Project-based learning (PBL) is gaining popularity in pedagogical and development projects. PBL in the classroom provides students with a meaningful learning experience [9], as it is a mode of instruction that allows students to utilize everyday objects as learning materials. As in [10],[11], project-based learning is an instructional approach that emphasizes assigning tasks, especially in the form of projects that can lead students to engage in an inquiry process. The use of project-based learning in the teaching-learning process has increased substantially, leading to serious discussions about its introduction [12]. Moreover, as stated in [13], some experts believe that project-based learning can motivate students to acquire new knowledge through their projects.

In conclusion, audiobook project-based learning needs to be applied to provide a wide chance for all students to improve their reading fluency. The research discovered on a. What effect does implementing audiobook project-based learning have on the reading fluency of English in Focus class students? b. What are the English in Focus students' perspectives after completing audiobook project-based learning? The research focuses on discovering the effect of audiobook projects on students' reading fluency. In addition, the research aimed to determine whether audiobooks can assist students in improving their reading fluency and what other effects they get based on the students' opinion after completing the project. Students may find that participating in audiobook project-based learning helps them improve their reading fluency. The students' reading fluency can be improved through the process of creating audiobooks, as it will require them to read the book multiple times.

II. METHOD

The research used a qualitative method to investigate the actual interference that occurred during foreign language reading materials [14]. The objective of the research was to determine the impact of the audiobook project on the reading fluency of students by analysing their opinions after the completion of the project. Qualitative research is appropriate because it elicits honest and original thoughts when examining the audiobook project.

A. Research participants

The population of the research was all students enrolled in English in Focus class in one university in Indonesia. The research used purposive sampling [14], to choose the participants of the research. As a result, the participants in the research who served as the samples were taken from two

different classes of English in Focus, and the total number of students who took part in the research was 83. In order for the students to enhance their reading fluency, they participated in the audiobook project by first constructing the audiobook as a group exercise.

B. Data collection technique and analysis

The research uses a questionnaire to get feedback from the participants about the audiobook project in order to determine how it has affected their reading fluency based on the students' perspective after completing the project. Within the questionnaire, there were two distinct sections, close-ended and open-ended questions. The first section had fifteen statements in the Likert scale (totally agree, agree, less agree, not agree) that asked students about the impact of doing an audiobook project on their reading fluency. The statements concerned the students' reading fluency prior to and after completing the audiobook project and their thoughts on both the audiobook project and the narrative they listened to. The second section was the open-ended questionnaire with two questions that asked students to describe the challenges and benefits of working on the audiobook project.

After that, the data were analyzed using grounded theory, also known as the inductive process [15]. The analytical process breaks up, conceptualizes, and puts together pieces of data to form results [16]. Finally, the discovered data were compared to the audiobook project theory proposed by the experts.

C. Research procedure

The audiobook implementation project was concluded within seven meetings. Students got used to listening to audiobooks before beginning each class meeting at the beginning of the semester as it helped them become accustomed to listen to English audio and knew about audiobooks. As in [10], the audiobook project-based learning consisted of three phases: planning, execution, and reporting (Figure 1). First, the planning stage consisted of five activities: selecting a project topic, conducting pre-communicative activities, posing essential questions, designing a project plan, and developing a project schedule. After being familiarized with audiobook, the students were informed that they would create the audiobook by themselves. The book the students should read was *The Tales of Beedle the Bard*, written by J.K. Rowling. It consisted of 5 short stories with 5 groups of them. One group consisted of eight to ten students who read one short story. The story was divided equally among them. The story was chosen because it involves descriptions of the environment and the events that take place, as well as dialogue between the characters that demands intonation as it is read.

Second, the implementation stage consisted of one activity, which was project completion. They worked together to create the audiobook in the form of a video (Figure 1). The students worked with their group and divided the story equally among the group members. Each student read the story, recorded, and combined them to become one full story. After that, they create the video that illustrated the story they have read, and it became the audiobook of its story. As the students read new words, they would find out how to read it correctly to improve their fluency. Finally, the last stage concluded with two activities: assessing project results and evaluating the project. The lecturer summarized the audiobook project, the benefit of doing the project, and the assessment of the activity, as shown in Figure 2.

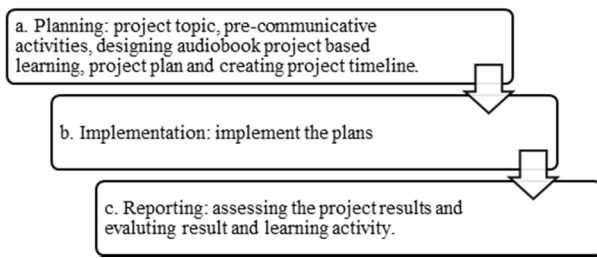


Fig. 1. Audiobook project procedure [10]

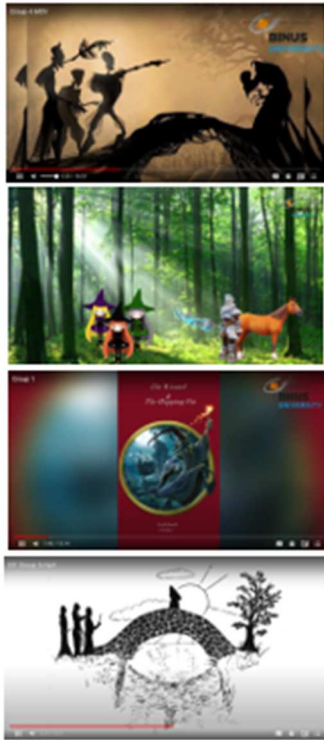


Fig. 2. Students' Audiobook Result

III. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Some findings were discovered after implementing the audiobook project in the class discussed in the section. The findings had been grouped into two main points, including students' reading fluency and the benefits of audiobook project implementation.

A. Reading fluency

The first data found was the students' reading fluency. Based on the questionnaire data, the students believed that their English reading fluency was good, and they could understand English text quite well. There were 8% who strongly agreed with the statement, 66% of them agreed, 24% of them less agreed, and only 1% did not agree. However, from the preliminary research data, it was found that the student's reading fluency still needed to be improved. Fluent reading depends on efficient, integrated, lower-level reading processes, such as phonemic awareness and knowledge of letter-sound correspondences, which result in automatic word recognition through practice [17]. When these processes were in place, students had a much higher probability of possessing the decoding skills necessary to accelerate their word reading, which facilitates reading fluency. The audiobook project-based learning helped students improve their reading fluency by having them repeatedly read the book aloud.

After that, according to questionnaire data, 27% of the students strongly agreed that they had a better reading experience after doing an audiobook project. 59% agreed, 10% less agreed, and 5% did not agree. The audiobook is categorized as a perspective reading type that involves the components of more significant stretches of discourse, such as letters, words, punctuation, and other graphemic symbols [18]. It is also categorized as a bottom-up process and usually short-length reading focusing on the form of the text. The audiobook facilitates and scaffolds the reading process as the student becomes a more proficient reader [19]. As in [20], improving reading fluency involves a variety of strategies, and audiobook projects as read-aloud strategies are essential reading techniques. Reading comprehension and fluency are the capacity to process text, an essential component of university student education.

And then, it was found that the students could demonstrate reading English text fluently in the audiobook project taken from questionnaire data. There were 20% of the students who strongly agreed, 63% agreed, 17% less, and none of them did not agree. Reading comprehension is a language skill identified as a crucial skill for all students to master because it enables students to gain a deeper understanding of the various types of information available in sources [2]. Furthermore, reading is not only intended to improve students' academic knowledge but also to provide them with enjoyment and happiness through recreational reading, as the audiobook project targeted. As also found by [21], the students noted that using audiobooks was a breakthrough in reading and listening comprehension. The students also mentioned that they encountered some difficulties while listening to the audiobooks; however, they were able to find practical solutions and even shared their thoughts on particular aspects of this activity.

Furthermore, 16% of 83 students argued that they could understand the story well based on the questionnaire data. Moreover, there were 72% agreed so, 11% less agreed, and 1% of them did not agree with the statement that they were able to acknowledge the material. It is in line with [22], that audiobooks were used in education as reading supplement materials to increase literacy. As in [1], it was also revealed that audiobooks could be used as a teaching tool to enhance students' reading comprehension by 11.26% of her research result. Besides, [23] discovered that audiobook projects as a read-aloud activity could improve students' reading comprehension. The improvement was evidenced by the rise in test scores, indicating construction and motivation. He also found that it effectively increased students' motivation to comprehend the texts, and also discovered that using audiobooks positively affected students' attitudes toward audiobooks and reading comprehension [24].

In conclusion, the audiobook is categorized as a reading-aloud activity focusing on recognizing alphabetic symbols, capitalized and lowercase letters, punctuation, words, and grapheme-phoneme correspondences. The audiobook project implementation enabled students to improve their reading fluency.

B. Benefit

The second data found was the benefit gained by the students after completing the audiobook project. The first benefit found was the students' vocabulary improvement. In the Audiobook project, the students demonstrate reading English text with good intonation and articulation. As a result,

the students gained new vocabulary working on an audiobook project. Among 83 students, 51% strongly agreed, 46% agreed, 2 %less agreed, and only 1% did not agree with the statement. Therefore, based on the questionnaire result, it can be concluded that the students expanded their vocabularies while working on the audiobook project. It is in line with [25], who exposed that the lecturer-provided materials improved reading skills for the project, and the students gained new vocabulary through reading the materials. Besides, the students could be exposed to the literature materials through the audiobook project, and as discovered [26], some university students believed reading was essential if it had to do with lectures or exams. However, it was incorrect that reading activity could be done not only about learning or examining but also in every reading material and every situation and condition as seen in Figure 3.

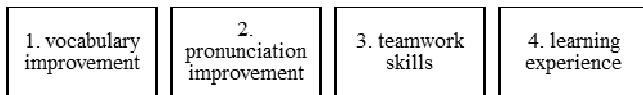


Fig. 3. Audiobook's benefit according to the students

Furthermore, the audiobook project served as an instructive platform for students, highlighting the multifaceted nature of reading activities beyond traditional lecture-based approaches. Each students had the potential to derive pleasure from engaging with various literary works, including but not limited to narratives and novels. The utilization of voice recordings as a means of capturing educational content imparts to students the ability to comprehend and interpret vocabulary contained within written texts. As students progressively acquire proficiency in a greater number of lexical items, their capacity to comprehend and effectively employ the language in both oral and written forms is correspondingly enhanced [27]. As in [28], students' vocabulary and comprehension skills improved after the read-aloud activity in their class. In addition, as they participated in discussions of the read-aloud stories, students could use the new vocabulary words and engage in analysis and synthesis. After that, a study by indicated that detail Information and vocabulary skills improved slightly after being taught using the reading aloud technique [29]. Although only those two aspects of reading improved, the method is still recommended to be used to teach reading. The second advantage was observed in the enhancement of students' pronunciation subsequent to their participation in the audiobook project. Within the context of the audiobook project, the students put forth the assertion that they possessed the ability to effectively showcase their proficiency in reading English text through the utilization of commendable intonation and articulation. There were 19% strongly agreed, 55% agreed, 25% less agreed, and none did not agree. It is in line with [30], who discovered that one of the audiobooks used was to improve students' pronunciation and motivation.

Then, based on the questionnaire data, 52% of students strongly agreed that they had looked for how to pronounce foreign words in English that they found in the story; the rest, 40% agreed, 5% less agreed, and only 4% of the students did not agree. According to [27], tone and pronunciation are crucial in learning a foreign language because tone and pronunciation determine the information's accuracy. In other words, the students can learn the right notes and pronunciation independently by doing the audiobook project.

The third benefit found in the class was the students' teamwork skills. Taken from the questionnaire data, more than half of the students had discussed the project with their group about the story before making the audiobook. As in [25], the Education and Culture Ministry has mandated that schools, beginning with primary schools, be responsible for guiding students toward developing good academic abilities, critical thinking, teamwork skills, and the ability to use technology. Learning experiences should be intentionally designed to incorporate essential skills that are relevant in the current era. One such crucial skill is collaboration. As found by [31],[32], the lecturer's most prevalent groupwork strategies are also popular among students. Additionally, also discovered in their research that most students enjoyed the tasks and would like to work in groups more frequently [33]. The method of group formation appeared to affect learning as well. They also found that social and academic variables such as age and GPA influenced group work formation, engagement, and outcomes.

The last benefit found was the students learning experience. According to the questionnaire data, most students did more than one trial during the audiobook project. Even 40% of them tried more than three times of trial. According to [34], the teaching process consisted of appropriate steps to the subject matter as they were the bridge to achieving the study's objective. The steps used by lecturers should also be relevant to student's needs, learning styles, and, in some cases, prior experiences. After the audiobook project, the students got used to pronouncing the words, reading English literature text, and gaining a learning experience [35].

Next, from questionnaire data, almost all the students felt that the audiobook project supports their reading experience. It is in line with [27] that students could be motivated to learn and gain experience from new learning approaches through e-learning since the product of the audiobook is in the form of video. [36] and [37] also discovered that the use of audiobooks in primary education may positively affect the learners and provide a learning experience that enables them to enhance their language proficiency and literary skills.

Furthermore, most students preferred to read literature materials rather than a scientific journal based on the research result. It was also found that 17% of the students liked reading activities. Furthermore, 61% of them agreed that they liked reading activities, and the rest, 22%, agreed with the statement. Therefore, it is in line with [20] findings that the read-aloud strategy was superior to silent reading and other reading strategies, particularly at the beginning reader level.

IV. CONCLUSION

The purpose of the research is to determine the effect of the audiobook project on students' reading fluency by using a questionnaire to express students' opinions about the audiobook project. According to the research findings, the students had overwhelmingly positive comments about their time spent participating in the project and learning English by using the audiobook project, and the students had the opportunity to improve their reading fluency. Moreover, the students also gained several benefits while working on the audiobook project, including the improvement of their vocabulary, pronunciation, teamwork, and learning experience. The implementation of project-based learning through audiobooks has the potential to enhance students' reading fluency by encouraging repeated oral reading of the text. In addition, the research contributes to the discovery of

the impact of audiobook project implementation on students' reading fluency. In addition, due to the research contributions, the findings can be utilized by other teachers who teach foreign languages and are contemplating project-based learning. There are two limitations to the research; the research provides information from the student's perspective only that it would be preferable to include data and information from the lecturer's perspective also; the data collection methods could be included classroom observation to observe what occurs in the classroom during the teaching-learning process. Due to the research limitation, additional research is required to address the research limitation.

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